

PSYCHIATRIC INTERVIEW QUESTIONS

Complete Clinician's Guide — All Questions for Every Section of Psychiatric History Taking (Based on Nitin Sethi Format)

1. Identification Data

Purpose: Establish rapport, gather demographic details, and assess reliability of the informant. Begin with open, non-threatening questions.

Basic Demographics

1. What is your full name?
2. How old are you? / What is your date of birth?
3. What is your gender?
4. What is your current marital status? (Single / Married / Divorced / Widowed / Separated)
5. What is your religion / faith / community?
6. What language do you primarily speak at home?
7. What is the highest level of education you have completed?
8. What is your current occupation? What work do you do?
9. Are you currently employed? If not, when did you last work?
10. What would you describe your family's socioeconomic status as? (Upper / Middle / Lower)
11. Where do you currently live? (Urban / Semi-urban / Rural)
12. What is your full current address?
13. Who has come with you today? What is their relationship to you?
14. Who knows you best and can give information about your illness?

Informant Assessment

1. How long have you known the patient?
2. Do you live with the patient? How often do you see them?
3. How well do you know the patient's daily routine and behavior?
4. Is there anything the patient might not want to share that you think is important for us to know?

Tip: Assess reliability by noting — does the informant give consistent details? Do they seem to exaggerate or minimize? Are they cooperative?

2. Chief Complaints

Purpose: Identify the primary reasons for seeking help in the patient's/informant's OWN words. Record duration for each complaint. List in chronological order of onset.

Eliciting Chief Complaints

1. What has brought you here today? / What is the main problem that made you come to see us?
2. Can you tell me in your own words what has been troubling you?
3. What are the main difficulties you have been facing recently?
4. Is there anything else that has been bothering you apart from what you just mentioned?
5. What would you say is the single biggest problem right now?

Duration & Onset for Each Complaint

1. When did this problem first start? How long have you been experiencing this?
2. Did it start suddenly one day, or did it come on slowly over time?
3. Can you remember the exact date or week when you first noticed it?
4. Was there anything happening in your life when this started? (Any stress, event, illness?)
5. Has this been getting worse, staying the same, or getting better since it started?
6. Is this problem present all the time, or does it come and go?

Intensity & Severity of Each Complaint

1. On a scale of 1 to 10, how severe would you rate this problem? (1 = very mild, 10 = worst imaginable)
2. How much does this problem interfere with your daily life and activities?
3. Does this problem stop you from doing things you normally do? Like what?
4. Has this problem affected your work / studies / household activities?
5. Has this problem affected your relationships with family or friends?
6. Has this problem affected your sleep, appetite, or self-care?

From the Informant

1. What changes have you noticed in the patient?
2. What is the main problem you have noticed? When did you first notice it?
3. How long has this been going on?
4. Is there anything the patient has not mentioned that you think is important?
5. What concerns you the most about the patient right now?

3. History of Present Illness (HOPI)

Purpose: Detailed chronological narrative of the current illness. Explore each symptom for onset, duration, intensity, course, progression, precipitating/aggravating/relieving factors, and functional impact.

Onset & Precipitating Factors

1. When exactly did you first start feeling unwell in this current episode?
2. Was the onset sudden (over days) or gradual (over weeks/months)?
3. What was happening in your life around the time the symptoms began?
4. Was there any stressful event — financial problems, relationship issues, job loss, bereavement, conflict, illness?
5. Were you physically unwell before the psychiatric symptoms started? Any fever, head injury, seizures?
6. Were you taking any new medications, drugs, or substances around that time?
7. Had you recently stopped any medications or substances?
8. Was there any change in your living situation, routine, or responsibilities?

Symptom Exploration — General Framework (Apply to EACH symptom)

For every symptom domain below, first establish PRESENCE or ABSENCE: "Have you experienced [symptom]? Yes or No." If YES, then ask all follow-up questions.

1. Presence: Have you experienced [specific symptom]? Is it present or absent?
2. Onset: When did this symptom first appear? Was it sudden or gradual?
3. Duration: How long have you had this symptom? Is it constant or intermittent?
4. Frequency: How often does it occur? (Every day? Several times a day? Weekly?)
5. Intensity/Severity: How severe is it on a scale of 1-10? How bad does it get at its worst?
6. Course: Has it been getting worse, better, or staying the same over time?
7. Aggravating factors: What makes it worse? Any situations, times of day, triggers?
8. Relieving factors: What makes it better? Anything that helps?
9. Associated symptoms: When this happens, do you notice anything else occurring at the same time?
10. Impact: How does this symptom affect your daily life, work, relationships, self-care?

Mood & Affect Symptoms

Depressed Mood

1. Have you been feeling sad, low, or down? (Present/Absent)
2. How long have you been feeling this way? (Duration)
3. Is the sadness there all day, or does it come and go?
4. On a scale of 1-10, how severe is the sadness at its worst? (Intensity)
5. Is there any particular time of day when you feel worse? (Morning/evening — diurnal variation)
6. Do you feel like crying? Do you actually cry? How often?
7. Do you feel hopeless — like things will never get better?

8. Do you feel worthless or like you are a burden to others?
9. Do you feel guilty about anything? What specifically?
10. Have you lost interest in things you used to enjoy? (Anhedonia — present/absent)
11. What activities have you stopped doing because of how you feel?

Elevated/Elated Mood

1. Have you been feeling unusually happy, elated, or on top of the world? (Present/Absent)
2. How long has this elevated mood lasted? (Duration)
3. Do others notice that you seem overly happy or excited? What do they say?
4. Do you feel like you have special powers, abilities, or importance?
5. Do you feel you need less sleep than usual but still feel energetic?
6. Have you been more talkative than usual? Do people say you talk too much?
7. Have you been spending more money than usual or making impulsive decisions?
8. Are your thoughts racing — like your mind is going very fast?
9. Have you been starting many new projects or activities?
10. Has this elevated mood caused any problems — at work, with family, financially?

Irritability

1. Have you been feeling more irritable or short-tempered than usual? (Present/Absent)
2. How long have you been feeling irritable? (Duration)
3. How intense is the irritability? Do small things make you very angry? (Intensity)
4. Do you lose your temper easily? How often?
5. Have you shouted at, threatened, or hit anyone because of your irritability?
6. What triggers your irritability? Any specific situations or people?
7. Can you control your anger, or does it feel out of control?

Anxiety

1. Have you been feeling anxious, nervous, or worried? (Present/Absent)
2. How long have you been feeling anxious? (Duration)
3. How severe is the anxiety — mild unease or severe panic? (Intensity, scale 1-10)
4. Is the anxiety about something specific, or is it general/free-floating?
5. Do you get sudden episodes of intense fear or panic? (Panic attacks — present/absent)
6. If panic attacks: How often do they occur? How long does each episode last? What symptoms do you get? (Palpitations, sweating, trembling, breathlessness, chest pain, dizziness, fear of dying)
7. Do you avoid certain places or situations because of anxiety? Which ones?
8. Do you have any specific fears or phobias? (Heights, closed spaces, crowds, social situations)
9. Do you worry excessively about many things? Can you control the worry?
10. Do you have physical symptoms with anxiety — trembling, sweating, palpitations, dry mouth, nausea?

Thought & Perception Symptoms

Delusions (Abnormal Beliefs)

1. Do you feel that people are against you or trying to harm you? (Persecution — present/absent)
2. Do you feel that people are talking about you, laughing at you, or referring to you? (Reference — present/absent)
3. Do you believe you have special powers, wealth, status, or a special mission? (Grandiosity — present/absent)
4. Do you feel that you have committed a great sin or done something terribly wrong? (Guilt — present/absent)
5. Do you believe something is wrong with your body — that it is rotting, diseased, or infested? (Somatic — present/absent)
6. Do you feel that your partner is being unfaithful? What makes you believe this? (Jealousy — present/absent)
7. Do you believe someone is in love with you? Who? (Erotomania — present/absent)
8. Do you feel that you or parts of the world don't exist? That everything is dead or gone? (Nihilistic — present/absent)
9. Do you feel that someone or something is controlling your thoughts, actions, or feelings? (Control — present/absent)
10. For each delusion present — When did this belief start? (Onset)

11. For each delusion present — How strongly do you believe this? Are you 100% certain? (Conviction)
12. For each delusion present — Is there any possibility you could be wrong about this?
13. For each delusion present — How does this belief affect your behavior? What have you done because of it?
14. For each delusion present — Is the belief interconnected with other beliefs? (Systematization)

Hallucinations (False Perceptions)

1. Do you hear voices or sounds that others cannot hear? (Auditory — present/absent)
2. If yes: How many voices? Male or female? Familiar or unfamiliar?
3. If yes: What do the voices say? Do they talk to you (2nd person) or about you (3rd person)?
4. If yes: Do the voices command you to do things? Have you obeyed?
5. If yes: Do the voices comment on what you are doing (running commentary)?
6. If yes: Where do the voices come from — inside your head or outside?
7. If yes: How often do you hear them? (Frequency) How long do they last each time? (Duration)
8. If yes: How loud are they? Can you ignore them? (Intensity)
9. If yes: When did you first start hearing them? (Onset)
10. If yes: Are they getting more frequent or louder over time? (Course)
11. Do you see things that others cannot see? (Visual — present/absent)
12. If yes: What do you see? (People, animals, shapes, colors, scenes?)
13. If yes: When do you see them — day or night? Eyes open or closed?
14. Do you smell things that others cannot smell? (Olfactory — present/absent)
15. Do you feel things on your skin — crawling, touching, burning — that aren't there? (Tactile — present/absent)
16. Do you taste things that aren't there or that others don't taste? (Gustatory — present/absent)

Thought Possession Abnormalities

1. Do you feel that thoughts are being put into your mind by someone else? (Thought insertion — present/absent)
2. Do you feel that your thoughts are being taken away or removed from your mind? (Thought withdrawal — present/absent)
3. Do you feel that others can hear your thoughts or know what you are thinking? (Thought broadcasting — present/absent)
4. Do you hear your own thoughts spoken aloud? (Thought echo — present/absent)
5. For each: When did this start? How often does it happen? How distressing is it?

Obsessions & Compulsions

1. Do you have repetitive thoughts that keep coming into your mind against your will? (Obsessions — present/absent)
2. If yes: What are these thoughts about? (Contamination, doubt, harm, symmetry, religious, sexual?)
3. If yes: How often do these thoughts come? (Frequency)
4. If yes: How distressing are they on a scale of 1-10? (Intensity)
5. If yes: Can you resist or stop these thoughts? What happens if you try?
6. If yes: Do you recognize these thoughts as your own? Do you know they are irrational?
7. Do you feel compelled to do certain actions repeatedly? (Compulsions — present/absent)
8. If yes: What do you feel compelled to do? (Washing, checking, counting, arranging, repeating?)
9. If yes: How many times do you repeat the action? How long does it take daily? (Duration)
10. If yes: What happens if you try to resist doing it? (Anxiety increases?)
11. If yes: Do you know that this behavior is excessive or unreasonable?
12. How long have you been having these obsessions/compulsions? (Duration of illness)

Biological Function Symptoms

Sleep

1. How is your sleep? Has there been any change in your sleep pattern? (Present/Absent)
2. What time do you go to bed? What time do you fall asleep?
3. How long does it take you to fall asleep? (Initial insomnia)
4. Do you wake up in the middle of the night? How many times? Can you go back to sleep? (Middle insomnia)
5. Do you wake up very early in the morning and cannot go back to sleep? What time? (Terminal/early morning insomnia)

6. How many total hours do you sleep per night?
7. Do you sleep excessively — more than 10-12 hours? (Hypersomnia — present/absent)
8. Do you feel rested after sleeping, or still tired?
9. Do you have nightmares or disturbing dreams? How often?
10. How long has your sleep been disturbed? (Duration)
11. How severe is the sleep problem — mild difficulty or cannot sleep at all? (Intensity)
12. What was your sleep like before this illness started? (Baseline)

Appetite & Weight

1. How is your appetite? Has it changed? (Increased/Decreased/Same — present/absent)
2. How many meals do you eat per day? How does this compare to before?
3. Do you have to force yourself to eat, or do you have no desire for food?
4. Or have you been eating much more than usual? Do you crave specific foods?
5. Have you gained or lost weight recently? How much? Over what period?
6. How long has your appetite been affected? (Duration)

Energy & Fatigue

1. How is your energy level? Do you feel tired or fatigued? (Present/Absent)
2. How severe is the tiredness — mild or completely exhausted? (Intensity)
3. Is the fatigue there all day from morning, or does it develop as the day goes on?
4. Has the fatigue affected your ability to do daily tasks — bathing, cooking, working?
5. How long have you been feeling this tired? (Duration)

Libido (Sexual Drive)

1. Has there been any change in your sexual interest or desire? (Increased/Decreased/Absent)
2. How long has this change been present? (Duration)
3. Has this caused any problems in your relationship?

Psychomotor Changes

1. Do you feel slowed down — like everything is in slow motion, including your thinking and movement? (Retardation — present/absent)
2. Or do you feel restless — unable to sit still, pacing, wringing hands? (Agitation — present/absent)
3. Have others noticed that you are moving or talking more slowly?
4. How long has this been present? (Duration)
5. How severe is it? Does it prevent you from completing tasks? (Intensity)

Diurnal Variation

1. Is there a time of day when you feel worse? Morning or evening?
2. Do your symptoms change throughout the day in a predictable pattern?

Cognitive Symptoms

1. Have you noticed any difficulty in concentrating or paying attention? (Present/Absent)
2. Can you read a newspaper article or watch a full TV program without your mind wandering?
3. Have you noticed any problems with your memory? (Present/Absent)
4. Do you forget recent events — like what you ate today or where you put things? (Recent memory)
5. Do you forget old memories — events from years ago? (Remote memory)
6. Have you felt confused or disoriented — not knowing where you are, what day it is, or who people are?
7. Have you had difficulty making decisions or thinking clearly?
8. How long have these cognitive difficulties been present? (Duration)
9. How severe are they — mild forgetfulness or seriously affecting daily function? (Intensity)
10. Are they getting worse over time? (Course)

Behavioral Symptoms

Aggression & Violence

1. Have you been aggressive or violent toward anyone? (Present/Absent)
2. What form did the aggression take — verbal (shouting, threatening) or physical (hitting, breaking things)?
3. How often have you been aggressive? (Frequency)

4. What triggers the aggression?
5. Have you injured anyone? Have you been arrested because of violent behavior?
6. Do you feel remorse after being aggressive?

Self-Harm & Suicidal Behavior

CRITICAL: These questions must always be asked. Ask directly and sensitively.

1. Have you felt that life is not worth living? (Present/Absent)
2. Have you wished you were dead or wished you could go to sleep and not wake up?
3. Have you had thoughts of harming yourself or ending your life? (Suicidal ideation — present/absent)
4. If yes: How often do these thoughts come? (Frequency)
5. If yes: How strong is the urge — a passing thought or an intense desire? (Intensity)
6. If yes: How long have you been having these thoughts? (Duration)
7. If yes: Have you thought about how you would do it? Do you have a plan? (Plan)
8. If yes: Have you made any preparations — collected pills, written a note, given away belongings?
9. If yes: What has stopped you from acting on these thoughts?
10. Have you ever attempted to end your life before? (Past attempts — present/absent)
11. If yes: When? What method? What happened? Were you hospitalized? What was your intent — did you want to die?
12. Have you harmed yourself without intending to die — cutting, burning, hitting yourself? (Self-harm — present/absent)
13. If yes: What do you do? How often? What triggers it? What does it do for you?
14. Do you have thoughts of harming others? (Homicidal ideation — present/absent)
15. If yes: Toward whom? Do you have a plan? How strong is the urge?

Social Withdrawal

1. Have you been withdrawing from family, friends, or social activities? (Present/Absent)
2. How long have you been isolating yourself? (Duration)
3. Do you stay in your room most of the day? Do you avoid meeting people?
4. Is this because you don't feel like socializing, or because you are afraid of something?

Decreased Self-Care

1. Have you been neglecting your personal hygiene — bathing, grooming, changing clothes? (Present/Absent)
2. How long has your self-care been affected? (Duration)
3. Are you able to cook, clean, or manage your daily routine?

Bizarre or Disorganized Behavior

1. Have you done anything that others found strange or unusual? (Present/Absent)
2. Have you been talking to yourself? Laughing or crying without reason?
3. Have you been collecting things, wandering, removing clothes in public, or doing things that don't make sense to others?
4. How long has this behavior been present? (Duration)

Course, Progression & Treatment

1. Overall, since the illness started, has it been continuous or does it come in episodes?
2. If episodic: How many episodes have there been? How long does each last? Do you recover completely between episodes?
3. Has the illness been getting progressively worse, staying stable, or improving?
4. Have you received any treatment for this current episode — medications, counseling, hospitalization?
5. If yes: What medications were prescribed? What dose? For how long? Did they help?
6. Did you experience any side effects from the medications?
7. Are you currently taking any psychiatric medication? Are you taking it regularly?
8. Have you had ECT (shock therapy) for this episode?
9. Have you been hospitalized for this episode? Where? For how long?
10. Why have you come for treatment now — what has changed or worsened?

Functional Impact

1. Has your illness affected your ability to work or study? In what way?

2. Has your illness affected your relationships — with spouse, children, parents, friends?
3. Has your illness affected your ability to care for yourself — eating, bathing, dressing?
4. Has your illness caused financial difficulties?
5. Has your illness affected your role in the family — as parent, spouse, earner?
6. Are you able to manage your household responsibilities?
7. Compared to before the illness, what percentage of your normal functioning would you say you are at now?

4. Past Psychiatric History

Purpose: Document all previous psychiatric episodes, treatments, and outcomes to understand the longitudinal course of illness.

Previous Episodes

1. Have you had any similar problems in the past before this current episode? (Present/Absent)
2. How many previous episodes have you had?
3. For each episode: When did it occur? (Year/approximate date)
4. For each episode: What symptoms did you have? Were they similar to now or different?
5. For each episode: How long did the episode last? (Duration)
6. For each episode: How severe was it? (Intensity)
7. For each episode: What was the diagnosis given at that time?
8. For each episode: What treatment did you receive — medications (names, doses), therapy, ECT?
9. For each episode: Did the treatment help? How much did you improve?
10. For each episode: Were you hospitalized? Where? For how long?
11. For each episode: Did you recover completely between episodes? Could you function normally?
12. For each episode: What triggered that episode? Was there a precipitating factor?
13. What was the longest period you remained well between episodes?
14. What was the shortest gap between episodes?
15. Have the episodes been getting worse over time, or are they similar each time?

Past Suicidal Behavior

1. Have you ever attempted suicide in the past? (Present/Absent)
2. If yes: How many times have you attempted?
3. For each attempt: When was it? What method did you use?
4. For each attempt: What was your intention — did you want to die?
5. For each attempt: Was it planned or impulsive?
6. For each attempt: How were you rescued? Did you seek help yourself?
7. For each attempt: Were you hospitalized? What treatment did you receive?
8. For each attempt: What were the circumstances — what was happening in your life?
9. For each attempt: How do you feel about that attempt now — regret, relief at surviving, or wish it had succeeded?

Treatment Adherence History

1. Have you ever stopped taking your psychiatric medications on your own? Why?
2. Have you ever stopped treatment because you felt better?
3. Have you ever stopped because of side effects? What side effects?
4. Have you ever missed follow-up appointments? Why?
5. What is your overall attitude toward psychiatric treatment and medications?

5. Past Medical & Surgical History

Purpose: Identify medical conditions that may cause or worsen psychiatric symptoms, and medications that may have psychiatric side effects.

Medical Illnesses

1. Do you have any medical conditions or physical illnesses? (Present/Absent)

2. Do you have diabetes? (Present/Absent) If yes: Since when? How is it controlled?
3. Do you have high blood pressure (hypertension)? (Present/Absent) If yes: Since when? On medication?
4. Do you have any thyroid problems — overactive or underactive thyroid? (Present/Absent)
5. Do you have epilepsy or seizures? (Present/Absent) If yes: Type, frequency, last seizure, medications?
6. Have you ever had a head injury or been unconscious? (Present/Absent) If yes: When? How severe? Any lasting effects?
7. Have you ever had a stroke (CVA)? (Present/Absent)
8. Do you have heart disease or any cardiac problems? (Present/Absent)
9. Do you have asthma or any lung disease? (Present/Absent)
10. Do you have any liver or kidney disease? (Present/Absent)
11. Have you been tested for HIV? What was the result? (Present/Absent)
12. Have you had hepatitis B or C? (Present/Absent)
13. Do you have any autoimmune disease — lupus, rheumatoid arthritis? (Present/Absent)
14. Do you have any neurological conditions — Parkinson's, multiple sclerosis, dementia? (Present/Absent)
15. Any other medical condition I haven't mentioned?
16. For each condition present: When was it diagnosed? What treatment are you on? Is it well-controlled?

Surgical History

1. Have you had any operations or surgeries in the past? (Present/Absent)
2. If yes: What surgery? When? Was there any complication?
3. Have you had any surgery on the brain or nervous system?
4. Did you have any psychiatric symptoms after any surgery? (Post-operative delirium, depression?)

Current Medications

1. What medications are you currently taking for your physical health?
2. For each: What is the name? What dose? How often? How long have you been taking it?
3. Are you taking steroids, beta-blockers, anti-epileptics, or any hormonal medications?
4. Have you noticed any mental changes since starting any medication?

Drug Allergies

1. Are you allergic to any medications? (Present/Absent)
2. If yes: Which medications? What kind of reaction did you have?
3. Have you ever had a severe allergic reaction (anaphylaxis) to any drug?

6. Substance Use History

Purpose: Assess use of all substances — tobacco, alcohol, cannabis, opioids, sedatives, stimulants, inhalants, and others. For each substance, determine pattern, quantity, dependence, and complications.

Screening Questions (Ask for EACH Substance)

1. Do you smoke cigarettes, beedis, or use tobacco in any form (chewing, gutka, snuff)? (Tobacco — present/absent)
2. Do you drink alcohol? (Alcohol — present/absent)
3. Do you use cannabis/marijuana/ganja/bhang/charas? (Cannabis — present/absent)
4. Do you use any opioids — heroin, opium, morphine, codeine, painkillers like tramadol? (Opioids — present/absent)
5. Do you use sleeping pills or anti-anxiety medications (benzodiazepines) without prescription? (Sedatives — present/absent)
6. Do you use stimulants — amphetamines, cocaine, methamphetamine? (Stimulants — present/absent)
7. Do you use inhalants — glue, petrol, whitener, paint thinner? (Inhalants — present/absent)
8. Do you use any other substances or drugs that I haven't mentioned?

Detailed Assessment for Each Substance Used

Initiation & Pattern

1. At what age did you first try this substance?
2. What were the circumstances — peer pressure, curiosity, stress relief, experimentation?

3. How did the use progress from first use to current use?
4. What is your current pattern — daily, weekends, binge, occasional?
5. How much do you use in a typical day/session? (Quantity)
6. What route do you use — oral, smoking, injection, snorting, inhalation?
7. When did you last use this substance? (Last use)

Duration & Escalation

1. How long have you been using this substance regularly? (Total duration)
2. Has the amount you use increased over time? By how much?
3. Do you need to use more now to get the same effect compared to when you started? (Tolerance — present/absent)

Dependence Features

1. Do you feel a strong desire or craving to use the substance? (Craving — present/absent)
2. Do you find it difficult to control when you start, when you stop, or how much you use? (Impaired control — present/absent)
3. Do you need to take more of the substance to get the same effect as before? (Tolerance — present/absent)
4. Do you get withdrawal symptoms when you stop or reduce use? (Withdrawal — present/absent)
5. If yes: What withdrawal symptoms do you get? (Describe: tremors, sweating, anxiety, seizures, body ache, cramps, insomnia, etc.)
6. Have you neglected other activities because of substance use — work, family, hobbies? (Neglect of alternatives — present/absent)
7. Do you continue using despite knowing it is causing you physical or mental harm? (Continued use despite harm — present/absent)
8. Has your use become the most important thing in your life? (Salience — present/absent)
9. Has your variety of substances narrowed — do you use only one now? (Narrowing of repertoire — present/absent)

Complications

1. Has substance use caused any physical health problems? (Liver disease, gastritis, neuropathy, lung disease, injection-site infections, HIV risk?)
2. Has substance use caused any psychiatric problems? (Depression, psychosis, anxiety, memory problems?)
3. Has substance use caused social problems? (Family conflict, divorce, job loss, legal problems, accidents?)
4. Has substance use caused financial problems?
5. Have you ever been treated for substance use before? What treatment? Did it help?
6. Have you ever tried to quit? How many times? What was the longest you stayed abstinent?
7. What is your current motivation to quit — do you want to stop?

7. Family History

Purpose: Identify genetic predisposition, family dynamics, expressed emotions, and psychosocial stressors from the family environment.

Family Composition & Structure

1. What type of family do you live in — nuclear (parents + children) or joint/extended? (Type)
2. How many members are in your family? Who are they?
3. Tell me about each family member — their age, education, occupation, and health status.
4. Are your parents alive? If deceased, what was the cause and when?
5. How many siblings do you have? What are their ages and what do they do?
6. Are your parents together, separated, or divorced?
7. Who is the primary earner in the family?
8. What is the overall financial status of the family?

Family History of Psychiatric & Medical Illness

1. Has anyone in your family ever had a mental health problem? (Present/Absent)
2. Has anyone in your family had depression or mood problems? (Present/Absent) Who?

3. Has anyone in your family had psychosis — hearing voices, strange beliefs, behaving oddly? (Present/Absent) Who?
4. Has anyone in your family had anxiety problems or panic attacks? (Present/Absent) Who?
5. Has anyone in your family used alcohol or drugs excessively? (Substance use — present/absent) Who?
6. Has anyone in your family attempted or completed suicide? (Present/Absent) Who? What happened?
7. Has anyone in your family had intellectual disability or learning problems? (Present/Absent)
8. Has anyone in your family had epilepsy or seizures? (Present/Absent)
9. Has anyone in your family had dementia or Alzheimer's? (Present/Absent)
10. Has anyone in your family been hospitalized for mental health problems? (Present/Absent) Who? Where? What treatment?
11. For each family member with psychiatric illness: What was the diagnosis? What treatment did they receive? What was the outcome?
12. Is there any other mental or neurological illness that runs in your family?

Family Dynamics & Relationships

1. How would you describe the atmosphere in your family — warm, cold, conflictual, supportive?
2. How is your relationship with your father? (Close/Distant/Conflictual)
3. How is your relationship with your mother? (Close/Distant/Conflictual)
4. How is your relationship with your siblings? (Close/Distant/Conflictual)
5. How is your relationship with your spouse (if married)? (Close/Distant/Conflictual)
6. Is there frequent conflict or fighting in the family? About what?
7. Has there been any domestic violence in the family? (Present/Absent) Physical? Emotional? Sexual?
8. Who do you feel closest to in your family? Who do you go to for support?
9. Do you feel your family understands your illness? Are they supportive?
10. How has your illness affected your family?
11. Is there high expressed emotion in the family — criticism, hostility, or over-involvement?

8. Personal History

Purpose: Comprehensive developmental and life history from birth to present — identifying vulnerabilities, stressors, and personality development.

Birth & Early Development (Prenatal, Perinatal, Postnatal)

1. Were you a planned/wanted pregnancy? (Ask informant if possible)
2. Were there any complications during your mother's pregnancy? (Present/Absent) (Infections, toxemia, substance use, emotional stress?)
3. Were you born at full term or premature? (Duration of pregnancy)
4. Was the delivery normal (vaginal) or by cesarean section?
5. Were there any complications during birth — prolonged labor, instrument use, birth asphyxia? (Present/Absent)
6. Did you cry immediately at birth? (Birth cry — present/absent)
7. What was your birth weight? Was it normal?
8. Were you kept in incubator or NICU? (Present/Absent)
9. Were you breastfed or bottle-fed? For how long?

Developmental Milestones

1. Did you achieve your developmental milestones at the normal age? (Normal/Delayed)
2. When did you first sit, crawl, stand, and walk? (Motor milestones — normal/delayed)
3. When did you first speak words and sentences? (Language milestones — normal/delayed)
4. When were you toilet trained? Were there difficulties? (Normal/Delayed)
5. Were there any concerns about your development as a child?
6. Did you have any childhood illnesses — measles, meningitis, febrile seizures, head injuries? (Present/Absent)

Childhood Behavioral Problems

1. Did you have any behavioral problems as a child? (Present/Absent)

2. Did you suck your thumb or bite your nails? (Present/Absent) Until what age?
3. Did you wet the bed (enuresis) beyond the normal age? (Present/Absent) Until what age?
4. Did you have temper tantrums? (Present/Absent) How severe? How frequent?
5. Did you have night terrors or nightmares? (Present/Absent)
6. Did you have separation anxiety — fear of going to school or being away from parents? (Present/Absent)
7. Were you a hyperactive child — unable to sit still, always running around? (Present/Absent)
8. Did you have problems paying attention in class? (Present/Absent)
9. Were you a loner as a child, or did you have friends?
10. Were you ever bullied at school? (Present/Absent) Or did you bully others?
11. Did you ever experience physical, emotional, or sexual abuse as a child? (Present/Absent)

Tip: Ask about abuse sensitively. "Sometimes children go through difficult experiences with adults. Did anything like that ever happen to you?"

Educational History

1. What schools did you attend? How far did you study?
2. How was your academic performance — above average, average, below average?
3. Did you fail any classes or have to repeat a year? (Present/Absent)
4. Did you have any learning difficulties — reading, writing, math? (Present/Absent)
5. How did you get along with your classmates and teachers?
6. Were you involved in extracurricular activities — sports, arts, clubs?
7. Did you have any disciplinary problems at school — truancy, fights, suspensions? (Present/Absent)
8. Why did you stop studying? (If not completed education)
9. Did your mental health ever affect your education? (Present/Absent)

Occupational History

1. What jobs have you held in your life? List them from first to current.
2. For each job: What was the role? How long did you work there?
3. For each job: Why did you leave? (Fired, resigned, conflict, illness?)
4. For each job: How did you get along with your colleagues and supervisors?
5. Have you had difficulty keeping a job? (Present/Absent) Why?
6. What is your current work status? (Employed/Unemployed/Unable to work)
7. How satisfied are you with your current job?
8. Are there any work-related stressors currently?
9. What is your current financial situation? Any debts or financial stress?
10. Has your illness affected your work? (Present/Absent) In what way?

Sexual & Marital History

Psychosexual Development

1. How did you learn about sex? (From parents, peers, school, media?)
2. At what age did you reach puberty?
3. What is your sexual orientation? (Heterosexual/Homosexual/Bisexual/Uncertain)
4. Have you had romantic relationships before marriage? (Present/Absent)
5. Have you experienced any sexual abuse or trauma? (Present/Absent)

Marital History (if applicable)

1. Are you married? At what age did you marry?
2. Was it an arranged or love marriage? Did you have a choice?
3. How is your relationship with your spouse? (Good/Fair/Poor/Conflictual)
4. Are there frequent arguments or fights? About what? (Present/Absent)
5. Is there any domestic violence in your marriage? (Physical/Emotional/Sexual — present/absent)
6. Are you satisfied with your married life?
7. Have you or your spouse been unfaithful? (Present/Absent)
8. Have you been separated or divorced? (Present/Absent) What were the reasons?
9. Do you have children? How many? Ages? How is your relationship with them?
10. Are there any sexual problems in the marriage? (Present/Absent)

11. If yes: What is the problem — low desire, erectile dysfunction, premature ejaculation, pain, inability to orgasm?
12. How long has the sexual problem been present? (Duration)
13. Is the sexual problem related to your psychiatric illness?

Menstrual & Reproductive History (for Female Patients)

1. At what age did you get your first period (menarche)?
2. Are your periods regular or irregular? (Regular/Irregular)
3. How many days does your period last? What is the cycle length?
4. Do you have heavy or painful periods? (Present/Absent)
5. When was your last menstrual period (LMP)?
6. Is there any chance you could be pregnant currently?
7. Have you reached menopause? At what age? Any symptoms?
8. How many pregnancies have you had? (Gravida)
9. How many deliveries? (Parity) How many were normal? Cesarean?
10. Have you had any miscarriages or abortions? (Present/Absent)
11. Did you have any psychiatric symptoms during pregnancy or after delivery? (Postpartum depression/psychosis — present/absent)
12. Are you using any contraception? What method?
13. Do you have premenstrual mood changes — irritability, sadness before periods? (PMS — present/absent)

Legal History

1. Have you ever been in trouble with the law? (Present/Absent)
2. Have you ever been arrested? For what? (Present/Absent)
3. Have you ever been in prison/jail? (Present/Absent) For how long?
4. Are there any pending legal cases against you? (Present/Absent)
5. Is your current psychiatric condition related to any legal issues?

9. Premorbid Personality

Purpose: Understand the patient's personality BEFORE the onset of illness — their "usual self" when well. Ask the informant to describe how the patient was before they became ill. This helps distinguish personality traits from illness symptoms.

Temperament & General Disposition

1. Before this illness, how would you describe yourself as a person — what kind of person were you?
2. Were you generally a cheerful/happy person or a serious/gloomy person?
3. Were you an outgoing person (extroverted) or a quiet/reserved person (introverted)?
4. Did you prefer being around people or being alone?
5. Were you an optimistic or pessimistic person?
6. Were you generally calm and relaxed, or anxious and tense?
7. Were you an energetic person or a low-energy person?
8. How did you typically react to stress or difficulties? What was your coping style?

Interpersonal Relationships & Social Life

1. Before this illness, how many close friends did you have?
2. Were your friendships deep and lasting, or superficial?
3. Did you trust people easily, or were you suspicious/guarded?
4. How did you get along with others — were you easy to get along with or difficult?
5. Were you socially confident or shy and anxious in social situations?
6. Did you enjoy social gatherings and parties, or did you avoid them?
7. How were your relationships with authority figures — respectful, rebellious, submissive?

Interests, Hobbies & Activities

1. What hobbies or interests did you have before this illness?
2. Were you involved in any clubs, organizations, or community activities?

3. Did you enjoy sports, reading, music, arts, or any creative activities?
4. How did you typically spend your free time?

Moral, Religious & Ethical Attitudes

1. How religious or spiritual are you? Is religion important in your life?
2. What are your moral values — are you strict or flexible about rules?
3. Are you rigid in your beliefs, or open to different viewpoints?
4. Have your religious beliefs or moral values changed since becoming ill?

Predominant Mood & Emotional Patterns

1. Before this illness, what was your usual mood — happy, sad, anxious, irritable, stable?
2. Did your mood tend to fluctuate a lot, or was it generally stable?
3. How did you typically handle frustration? Did you get angry easily?
4. How did you react to disappointment or failure?
5. Were you an emotional/sensitive person or more logical/rational?
6. How did you handle stressful situations — did you cope well or break down?

Character Traits & Habits

1. Were you a responsible and reliable person?
2. Were you self-confident or did you doubt yourself a lot?
3. Were you independent or dependent on others?
4. Were you impulsive — acting without thinking — or careful and planned?
5. Were you a perfectionist? Were you orderly and organized?
6. Were you stubborn or flexible? Did you like things your own way?
7. Were you a risk-taker or cautious?
8. How did you make decisions — quickly or after much deliberation?
9. Were you truthful and honest, or did you tend to lie or manipulate?
10. Were you generous or stingy with money?
11. What were your eating and sleeping habits like before this illness?

10. Mental Status Examination (MSE)

Purpose: Systematic assessment of the patient's current mental state at the time of examination. This is the psychiatric equivalent of a physical examination. Some aspects are observed (appearance, behavior, affect), while others require direct questioning (mood, thought content, perception, cognition).

General Appearance & Behavior

Tip: Much of this section is OBSERVED rather than asked. Note your observations systematically. Some questions are directed to the patient to clarify observations.

Appearance (Observe)

1. What is the patient's build — thin, average, obese? (Observe)
2. Does the patient look their stated age, older, or younger? (Observe)
3. How is the patient's hygiene and grooming — clean, unkempt, malodorous? (Observe)
4. How is the patient dressed — appropriate, bizarre, disheveled? (Observe)
5. Are there any visible injuries, scars (especially self-harm scars), or physical abnormalities? (Observe)
6. Does the patient appear well-nourished or malnourished? (Observe)
7. Is there anything unusual about the patient's appearance that stands out? (Observe)

Psychomotor Activity (Observe & Ask)

1. Is the patient sitting still, or are they restless/agitated? (Observe)
2. Is the patient moving slowly — slowed movements, slowed speech? (Psychomotor retardation — observe)
3. Are there any abnormal movements — tremors, tics, mannerisms, stereotypies? (Observe)
4. Is the patient pacing, fidgeting, wringing hands, or unable to sit still? (Agitation — observe)
5. Are there any catatonic features — waxy flexibility, posturing, negativism, mutism? (Observe)
6. How is the patient's gait — normal, shuffling, unsteady? (Observe)

Attitude & Rapport

1. How is the patient's attitude — cooperative, hostile, guarded, suspicious, evasive, seductive, indifferent? (Observe)
2. Is the patient making eye contact? (Normal/Fleeting/Avoidant/Staring — observe)
3. Was rapport easy to establish or difficult? (Observe)
4. Does the patient seem interested in the interview, or disengaged? (Observe)
5. Is the patient answering questions willingly and fully, or being evasive? (Observe)

Speech

Tip: Assess speech characteristics throughout the interview by observation. Note rate, rhythm, volume, tone, spontaneity, and relevance.

1. Is the patient's speech rate normal, increased (pressure of speech), or decreased (poverty of speech)? (Observe)
2. Is the volume normal, too loud, or too soft/whispered? (Observe)
3. Is the tone normal, monotonous, or high-pitched? (Observe)
4. Is the speech fluent, hesitant, stuttering, or slurred (dysarthric)? (Observe)
5. Is the speech spontaneous or only in response to direct questions? (Observe)
6. Is the content relevant and goal-directed, or irrelevant and rambling? (Observe)
7. Is the speech coherent (can you understand what they are saying)? (Observe)
8. Are there any neologisms (made-up words)? (Observe)
9. Is there echolalia (repeating your words)? (Observe)
10. Is there mutism (not speaking at all)? (Observe)

Mood & Affect

Mood (Subjective — Ask the Patient)

1. How are you feeling right now, at this moment?
2. How would you describe your mood today? (In your own words)
3. If you had to pick one word to describe how you feel inside, what would it be?
4. On a scale of 1-10, where 1 is the worst you've ever felt and 10 is the best, where are you now?
5. Has your mood been the same over the past few days, or does it change?

Affect (Objective — Observe)

1. What is the predominant affect observed — euthymic, depressed, elated, anxious, irritable, flat, blunted? (Observe)
2. What is the range of affect — full range, restricted, blunted, or flat? (Observe)
3. Is the affect reactive — does it change in response to different topics? (Observe)
4. Is the affect congruent with the stated mood and thought content? (Observe — e.g., smiling while describing sadness = incongruent)
5. Is the affect labile — changing rapidly and unpredictably? (Observe)
6. Is the affect appropriate to the context of conversation? (Observe)

Thought — Form (Stream & Flow)

Tip: Thought form is assessed by how the patient speaks — the organization and flow of their thoughts. Listen to the pattern of their speech during the interview.

1. Is the patient's thinking goal-directed — do they answer questions in a logical, organized way? (Observe)
2. Is there flight of ideas — rapid jumping from topic to topic with loose connections? (Present/Absent — observe)
3. Is there loosening of associations — disconnected thoughts with no logical link? (Present/Absent — observe)
4. Is there tangentiality — going off on tangents and never answering the original question? (Present/Absent — observe)
5. Is there circumstantiality — eventually reaching the point but taking a very long, roundabout way? (Present/Absent — observe)
6. Is there thought blocking — sudden stopping mid-sentence with inability to continue? (Present/Absent — observe)
7. Is there perseveration — repeating the same word or phrase over and over? (Present/Absent — observe)

8. Are there neologisms — made-up words? (Present/Absent — observe)
9. Is there word salad — completely incomprehensible speech? (Present/Absent — observe)
10. Are there clang associations — words chosen by sound rather than meaning? (Present/Absent — observe)
11. Is the amount of thought increased (pressure) or decreased (poverty)? (Observe)

Thought — Content

Delusions (Ask Directly)

1. Do you have any beliefs that others might find unusual or hard to understand?
2. Do you feel anyone is trying to harm you, follow you, or plot against you? (Persecution — present/absent)
3. Do you feel people are talking about you or referring to you — on TV, radio, or in public? (Reference — present/absent)
4. Do you believe you have special powers, abilities, wealth, or a special mission from God? (Grandiosity — present/absent)
5. Do you feel you have done something terrible or committed a great sin? (Guilt — present/absent)
6. Do you believe something is wrong with your body — rotting, infested, not working? (Somatic — present/absent)
7. Do you believe your spouse/partner is unfaithful? What evidence do you have? (Jealousy — present/absent)
8. Do you believe that everything is hopeless, that you or the world don't exist? (Nihilistic — present/absent)
9. Do you feel that external forces are controlling your thoughts, feelings, or actions? (Control/passivity — present/absent)
10. For each delusion: How firmly do you believe this? Could you be wrong? (Conviction)
11. For each delusion: When did you start believing this? (Onset)
12. For each delusion: How has this belief affected your behavior?

Obsessions (Ask Directly)

1. Are there any thoughts that keep coming into your mind again and again that you cannot stop? (Present/Absent)
2. What are these thoughts about? How distressing are they?
3. Do you recognize them as your own thoughts? Do you know they are irrational?

Phobias (Ask Directly)

1. Are you extremely afraid of any specific thing or situation — beyond what is reasonable? (Present/Absent)
2. What are you afraid of? What happens when you encounter it?
3. Do you avoid situations because of fear? What do you avoid?

Suicidal & Homicidal Ideation (Ask Directly)

1. Right now, are you having any thoughts of harming yourself or ending your life? (Present/Absent)
2. Right now, are you having any thoughts of harming anyone else? (Present/Absent)
3. If present: How strong is the urge right now? Do you feel safe?

Overvalued Ideas

1. Is there any idea or belief that occupies your mind excessively — that you feel very strongly about? (Present/Absent)
2. Can you see other people's point of view about this, even if you disagree?

Thought — Possession

1. Do you feel that thoughts are being put into your mind from outside — that they are not your own? (Thought insertion — present/absent)
2. Do you feel that your thoughts are being taken away or removed from your mind? (Thought withdrawal — present/absent)
3. Do you feel that other people can know or hear your thoughts — that your thoughts are broadcast to the world? (Thought broadcasting — present/absent)
4. Do you hear your own thoughts spoken aloud, as if echoed? (Thought echo/Gedankenlautwerden — present/absent)

Perception

Hallucinations (Ask Directly for Each Modality)

1. Do you hear voices or sounds when there is nobody around? When nobody else can hear them? (Auditory hallucinations — present/absent)
2. If present: Is it one voice or multiple voices? Male or female? Familiar or unfamiliar?
3. If present: Do the voices speak to you directly (2nd person) or talk about you to each other (3rd person)?
4. If present: What do they say? Do they give you commands? Have you obeyed their commands?
5. If present: Do they comment on what you are doing as you do it? (Running commentary)
6. If present: Do the voices come from inside your head or from outside — a specific location?
7. If present: How loud are they — whispered, normal volume, shouting? (Intensity)
8. If present: How often do you hear them — constantly, several times daily, occasionally? (Frequency)
9. If present: How long do they last each time? (Duration of each episode)
10. If present: When did you first start hearing them? (Onset)
11. If present: Are they getting more or less frequent over time? (Course)
12. If present: Do they distress you? Do they make you do things?
13. Do you see things that others cannot see — people, shapes, shadows, animals? (Visual hallucinations — present/absent)
14. If present: What do you see? Is it clear and formed, or vague and shapeless?
15. If present: When do they occur — day/night? Eyes open/closed? Dark/light?
16. Do you feel things on your skin — touching, crawling, insects, electricity — that aren't there? (Tactile hallucinations — present/absent)
17. Do you smell things that others cannot smell — foul or unusual odors? (Olfactory hallucinations — present/absent)
18. Do you taste things in your mouth that shouldn't be there — poison, strange taste? (Gustatory hallucinations — present/absent)

Other Perceptual Disturbances

1. Do things around you sometimes look distorted — bigger, smaller, farther, or different than usual? (Illusions/distortions — present/absent)
2. Do you sometimes feel that you are unreal — detached from yourself, watching yourself from outside? (Depersonalization — present/absent)
3. Do you sometimes feel that the world around you is unreal — like a dream or a movie? (Derealization — present/absent)
4. If present: How often does this happen? How long does it last? How distressing is it?

Cognition

Consciousness & Orientation

1. Is the patient alert and awake? Or drowsy, confused, semiconscious? (Observe level of consciousness)
2. What is today's date? What day of the week is it? What month? What year? (Orientation to time)
3. Where are we right now? What is this place? What city are we in? What floor? (Orientation to place)
4. What is your name? Who am I? Who is the person who came with you? (Orientation to person)

Attention & Concentration

1. Can you count backwards from 20 to 1? (Serial subtraction test)
2. Can you subtract 7 from 100, then keep subtracting 7? (Serial 7s: 100, 93, 86, 79...)
3. Can you spell the word "WORLD" backwards? (W-O-R-L-D D-L-R-O-W)
4. Can you name the days of the week backwards? (Saturday, Friday, Thursday...)
5. Can you name the months of the year backwards? (December, November, October...)
6. I'm going to say some numbers — please repeat them after me: 5-8-2, 6-9-4-7, 3-1-8-5-2 (Digit span forward)
7. Now repeat these numbers backwards: 2-4, 6-2-9, 3-9-1-4 (Digit span backward)

Memory

1. I'm going to tell you three words. Please remember them: "Apple, Table, Penny." Now repeat them. (Immediate recall/Registration)
2. After 5 minutes: Can you tell me the three words I asked you to remember? (Short-term/Recent memory)
3. What did you have for breakfast today? What did you do yesterday? (Recent memory)

4. When is your birthday? What year were you married? What school did you go to? (Remote/Long-term memory)
5. Who is the current Prime Minister/President? Who was before them? (General knowledge/Remote memory)
6. Can you tell me what happened in the news recently? (Recent memory + awareness)

Intelligence (Clinical Estimate)

1. What is your level of education and academic performance? (Background information)
2. How many states are there in India / countries in Europe? (General knowledge)
3. What is the capital of [country]? (General knowledge)
4. How far is it from [city A] to [city B]? (Estimation)
5. If you have 18 books and give away half, how many do you have? (Simple arithmetic)
6. If something costs Rs.80 and you pay with Rs.100, how much change do you get? (Practical arithmetic)

Abstract Thinking

1. What does this proverb mean: "A stitch in time saves nine"? (Proverb interpretation — abstract vs concrete?)
2. What does "People in glass houses shouldn't throw stones" mean?
3. What does "Don't cry over spilt milk" mean?
4. How are an apple and an orange similar? (Similarities — abstract: both fruits / concrete: both round)
5. How are a table and a chair similar?
6. How are a poem and a statue similar?
7. What is the difference between a lie and a mistake?
8. What is the difference between a child and a dwarf?

Judgment

Social Judgment (Practical Scenarios)

1. What would you do if you found a stamped, addressed envelope on the road? (Test judgment)
2. What would you do if you were in a crowded cinema and saw fire/smoke? (Test judgment)
3. What would you do if a stranger on the street asked you to keep their bag for them? (Test judgment)
4. What would you do if you saw a house on fire? (Test judgment)
5. How do you handle your money — can you manage your finances independently?
6. Are you currently making any important decisions — about marriage, money, job, property? Are these reasonable?

Personal Judgment

1. Do you think you are ill? (Assess awareness)
2. What do you think is causing your problems?
3. Do you think you need treatment? What kind of treatment?
4. What are your plans for the future — short-term and long-term?
5. Are these plans realistic given your current situation?

Insight

Insight is graded from Grade 1 (complete denial of illness) to Grade 6 (true emotional insight). Assess by asking the following questions:

1. Do you think there is anything wrong with you? Do you think you are ill? (Grade 1 if complete denial)
2. Do you think something might be wrong, but you're not sure what? (Grade 2 — slight awareness)
3. Do you think something is wrong, but it's caused by others/external factors — not an illness? (Grade 3 — aware but blames external)
4. Do you feel something is wrong with you but you don't know what exactly? (Grade 4 — aware something is wrong)
5. Do you think you have a mental illness? Do you understand what the illness is? (Grade 5 — intellectual insight)
6. Do you understand what caused your illness, what keeps it going, and what you need to do to get better? (Grade 6 — emotional insight)
7. Do you think you need treatment? Will you take medications regularly?
8. Do you think the symptoms you described are part of an illness, or do you think they are real/normal?
9. What do you think will happen if you don't take treatment?

11. Diagnosis & Formulation

Purpose: Integrate all information to arrive at a diagnosis and formulation. These are clinician-directed questions to guide diagnostic thinking.

Diagnostic Clarification Questions

1. Based on the symptoms described, do they meet criteria for a specific ICD-10/DSM-5 diagnosis?
2. Are the symptoms better explained by a medical condition or substance use?
3. Is the duration of symptoms sufficient to meet diagnostic criteria?
4. Is there significant distress or functional impairment (clinical significance criterion)?
5. Are there symptoms of more than one disorder (comorbidity)?
6. What differential diagnoses need to be considered and ruled out?

Formulation Questions (4 P's Framework)

Predisposing Factors

1. Is there a family history of similar illness (genetic vulnerability)?
2. Were there developmental problems, childhood adversity, or trauma?
3. Are there personality traits that increase vulnerability?
4. Were there early attachment difficulties?

Precipitating Factors

1. What triggered this current episode — life events, stressors, losses?
2. Was there a medical illness, substance use, or medication change preceding onset?
3. Was there a relationship breakdown, bereavement, or financial crisis?

Perpetuating Factors

1. What is maintaining the illness — ongoing stressors, poor support, non-adherence?
2. Are there maintaining cognitive patterns — negative thinking, avoidance?
3. Is there ongoing substance use worsening the condition?
4. Is the family environment maintaining the illness — high expressed emotion, enabling?

Protective Factors

1. What are the patient's strengths — intelligence, insight, motivation?
2. Is there good social support — family, friends, community?
3. Has the patient responded well to treatment in the past?
4. Are there good coping skills, religious faith, or other resources?

12. Treatment Plan

Purpose: Questions to guide treatment planning — biological, psychological, and social interventions.

Treatment History & Preferences

1. Have you had any treatment before for this condition? What worked and what didn't?
2. Are you willing to take medications? Do you have concerns about medications?
3. Have you had bad experiences with medications in the past — side effects?
4. Are you open to counseling/therapy? Have you had therapy before?
5. What are your expectations from treatment? What do you hope to achieve?
6. Are there any treatments you would refuse — ECT, hospitalization, specific medications?
7. Do you have access to follow-up care — can you come for regular appointments?
8. Can you afford medications? Is there financial constraint for treatment?
9. Who at home can supervise your medications and ensure you take them regularly?

Risk Assessment Questions

1. Do you feel safe right now? Is there any immediate danger to yourself or others?
2. Do you have access to means of self-harm — medications, sharp objects, pesticides, firearms?
3. Is there someone who can stay with you and ensure your safety?

4. Can we make a safety plan together — what will you do if you feel like harming yourself?
5. Are you willing to come to the emergency department if you feel unsafe?
6. Can I speak with your family member about keeping you safe?

Investigations Needed

1. Have you had any blood tests done recently? (CBC, LFT, KFT, Thyroid, Blood sugar)
2. Have you had any brain imaging — CT scan or MRI? (If indicated)
3. Have you had an EEG? (If seizures suspected)
4. Have you had psychological testing done? (IQ testing, personality assessment, neuropsychological testing)
5. Are there any medical investigations pending that might explain your symptoms?

Closing the Interview

1. Is there anything else you want to tell me that I haven't asked about?
2. Is there anything you're worried about that we haven't discussed?
3. Do you have any questions for me?
4. Is there anything you want to add that might help me understand your situation better?
5. Do you feel comfortable with the plan we've discussed?
6. Who should I contact if there's an emergency? What is their phone number?